Julkipli M. Wadi

Prof. Julkipli M. Wadi is a Filipino Muslim scholar, educator, political analyst, and one of the most respected voices on Islam, governance, and the Bangsamoro question in the Philippines today. A Tausug intellectual from Jolo, Sulu, he has spent more than two decades at the **University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies (UP IIS)** in Diliman, where he has served as dean across four terms, including his most recent appointment covering 2025 to 2028. Wadi's signature legacy is the bridge he's spent a career building: between classical Islamic learning and modern political analysis, between Muslim and non-Muslim Filipino communities, and between the ivory tower and the urgent, lived realities of Mindanao and the broader Muslim world. He edits the *Pangadjian* Journal of Islamic Studies and writes the widely-read "Crucible" column for MindaNews, making him one of the few Muslim Filipino academics who consistently reaches both scholarly and public audiences.

Early Life and Background

Julkipli M. Wadi was born and raised in Jolo, Sulu, in the heart of Tausug country in the southern Philippines. Growing up in that environment shaped him in fundamental ways: Jolo has always been a place where Islam, culture, history, and politics are not separate subjects but a single, lived reality. He absorbed Bahasa Sug, the Tausug language, alongside Jawi script as a child, giving him a linguistic and cultural grounding that has informed his scholarship throughout his career. His early years exposed him to the complex history of the Bangsamoro people, including the long struggle for recognition, autonomy, and justice that would later become a central concern in his academic and public work.

Education

Wadi's educational journey is itself a story of two worlds weaving together. In the late 1970s and early 1980s, he studied at the **Yahya Radjaie Memorial Islamic School** in Jolo, a madrasa where he received a classical Islamic formation under teachers including Ustadh Abduraqib Azhari and Tuan Sharif Mudar. The curriculum covered the full range of traditional Islamic sciences: Quran and its recitation, Hadith, Seerah (prophetic biography), Shariah, Fiqh (Islamic jurisprudence), and Arabic grammar, among others. At the same time, he attended **Notre Dame of Jolo for Boys** for his conventional secondary education, graduating as the **Batch '86 valedictorian**, a distinction that speaks to his early intellectual seriousness.

After passing the UP College Admission Test (UPCAT) in 1986, family priorities kept him from enrolling immediately at the national university. He passed through UST and Mapua before eventually settling at the **University of the East (UE)**, where he completed his **Bachelor of Arts in Political Science**. That detour turned out to be formative: political science gave him a systematic framework for analyzing power, governance, and social movements, which he would later apply directly to Muslim Filipino experience.

He finally arrived at UP in 1990, completing his **Master of Arts in Islamic Studies** at the Institute in **1993**. His MA thesis examined Islamic diplomacy and the role of the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) in the Bangsamoro question, a topic that sat squarely at the intersection of his two disciplines. He also undertook doctoral coursework in Political Science at UP, though he did not complete a PhD. That dual foundation in political science and Islamic studies became his distinctive analytical lens.

Academic Career

Wadi's career at UP IIS unfolded gradually and organically. He began as a part-time researcher and research associate before moving into a full faculty role, then college secretary, and eventually the deanship. He **first became dean around 2009**, and has since served through a second term beginning in 2012, a third term approved in 2022, and a **fourth term covering 2025 to 2028**, reappointed in early 2025. The sustained trust placed in him by the university reflects both his institutional knowledge and his steady, principled leadership style.

In the classroom, Wadi covers a rich and demanding curriculum. His courses include Islamic Revivalism and Contemporary Movements, Kalam and Islamic Philosophy, Islamic Political Thought, Tafsir (Quranic commentary), Islamic History, Arabic Historiography, Islamic Civilization, Islamic Economics, and Islam in Southeast Asia. He has mentored graduate students at UP across many years, and has lectured at institutions including the **National Defense College of the Philippines** and the **University of Santo Tomas**.

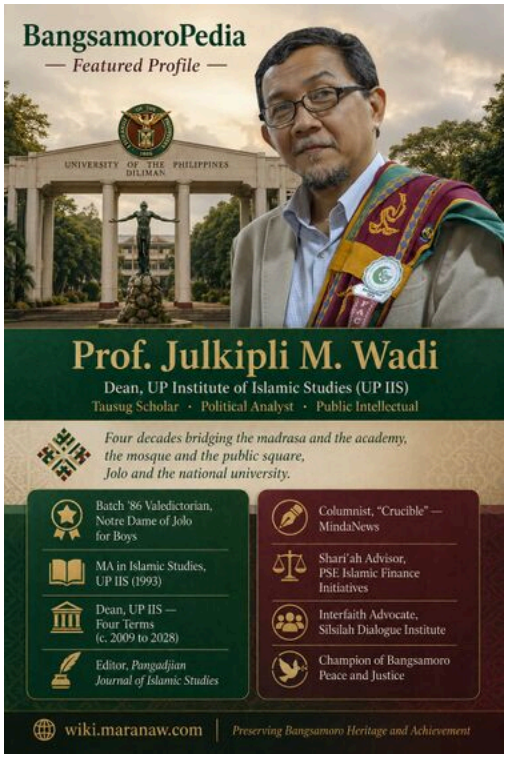
His research agenda is consistent and coherent: Philippine Muslim history, the Bangsamoro struggle, the Mindanao conflict, Islamic political thought, and interfaith dialogue. He approaches these subjects not as separate fields but as interconnected dimensions of a single, ongoing story.

Scholarly Work and Publications

Wadi's published output reflects the same dual commitment that has defined his career: rigorous scholarship and accessible public writing. His 1993 MA thesis on Islamic diplomacy and the OIC's relationship to the Bangsamoro question remains an important early contribution to the field. He has written on Philippine political Islam, Moro political dynasties, the phenomenon of multiple colonialism in Moroland, and contributed chapters and essays to edited volumes on Mindanao narratives. His 2005 piece **«Braving Muslim–Christian Dialogue in the Philippines»** stands as one of his more widely cited contributions to the interfaith literature.

As editor of the ***Pangadjian* Journal of Islamic Studies**, he has helped shape the direction of Islamic scholarship in the Philippine academic context. His **«Crucible» column in MindaNews** reaches a broader readership, offering analysis on regional security, the Mindanao peace process, global Muslim issues, and moral dimensions of contemporary politics. The column is notable for its combination of scholarly grounding and clear, accessible prose, and it has established him as one of the most consistent public intellectuals on Bangsamoro and Islamic affairs in the country.

Prof. Julkipli M. Wadi



Personal Information	
Full Name	Julkipli M. Wadi
Ethnicity	Tausug
Origin	Jolo, Sulu, Philippines
Education	
Madrasa	Yahya Radjaie Memorial Islamic School, Jolo
Secondary	Notre Dame of Jolo for Boys (Batch '86 Valedictorian)
Bachelor's	BA in Political Science, University of the East
Master's	MA in Islamic Studies, UP Institute of Islamic Studies (1993)
Doctoral	PhD coursework in Political Science, University of the Philippines (incomplete)
Career	
Position	Dean, UP Institute of Islamic Studies

He has built academic linkages across Southeast Asia, the Middle East, Japan, Europe, and North America, and has co-organized research consortia spanning multiple institutions.

Tenure as Dean	1st term c. 2009; 2nd term 2012; 3rd term 2022; 4th term 2025–2028
Field	Islamic Studies, Political Science, Bangsamoro Studies
Publications	
Journal	*Pangadjian* Journal of Islamic Studies (Editor)
Column	"Crucible," MindaNews

Public Engagement and Media

Wadi has never been the kind of academic who stays locked in the university. He appears regularly in media as a political analyst, offering commentary on Islam and Philippine politics, the Mindanao peace process, and broader developments in the Muslim world. He has spoken at national and international conferences and has been a consistent voice in public discourse on issues that many analysts treat superficially. His approach to media is measured and principled: he explains, contextualizes, and challenges stereotypes rather than simply confirming them.

He has spoken and written movingly on Palestine, Gaza, and global calls for solidarity and empathy, framing these issues within a broader ethical and humanist framework rather than as narrowly political talking points.

Community, Interfaith, and Advisory Work

Beyond academia and media, Wadi is also a man of practice. He serves as **imam and khatib** at the institute and at other venues, a role that keeps him anchored in the spiritual and communal dimensions of Islam rather than just its theoretical study.

His ties to the **Silsilah Dialogue Institute** in Zamboanga are long-standing, reflecting a sustained personal commitment to Muslim–Christian dialogue as a practical peacebuilding tool, not just an academic subject.

On the community development side, he was involved in a **peace, development, and microfinance pilot project** in Barangay Siunugan, Indanan, Sulu. The project integrated conflict resolution, women's empowerment, and environmental rehabilitation, demonstrating his interest in connecting Islamic values to grassroots development work.

On the institutional advisory side, he has sat on the advisory group for the **Philippine Stock Exchange's Islamic finance initiatives**, and chairs or serves on Shari'ah compliance boards for microfinance and takaful (Islamic insurance) organizations. These roles reflect a rare versatility: few Filipino Islamic scholars have moved comfortably across the university, the mosque, civil society, and the financial sector.

Institutional Contributions

As dean of UP IIS across four terms, Wadi has shaped the institute's academic direction, faculty development, and public profile over more than a decade. He has worked to position UP IIS as the leading academic center for Islamic Studies in the Philippines, strengthening its curriculum, research output, and connections to both local Muslim communities and international academic networks. His editorship of the *Pangadjian* Journal has raised the institute's scholarly profile, and his own prolific writing has kept the institute visible in national public discourse. He has championed the importance of understanding Islam and the Bangsamoro experience not as peripheral or specialized concerns but as central to any serious engagement with Philippine history, identity, and governance.

Personal Life and Values

Details about Wadi's immediate family remain largely private, in keeping with his reserved personal style. He is married, and occasional glimpses in his writing reveal a man with warmth, humor, and a deeply relational sense of the world. In one column, he recounted a visit to a Palestinian art event where he and his wife noticed another "Wadi" (the artist Ala Wadi) among the exhibitors, prompting a lighthearted exchange about possible Palestinian family connections. Small moments like these show the human texture behind the scholar.

His values come through consistently across everything he does: a commitment to dialogue across religious and cultural divides, ethical seriousness in his engagement with politics and power, advocacy for justice and peace in Mindanao, and a humanist insistence on shared humanity in the face of global conflicts.

Legacy

In the wider landscape of Philippine intellectual and public life, Julkipli M. Wadi occupies a distinctive and important place. He is one of the few Filipino scholars who can move fluently between the madrasa tradition and the national university, between the mosque and the boardroom, between the academic journal and the newspaper column. As a Tausug intellectual who made his mark at the national university while staying rooted in the culture, language, and concerns of his home community, he models a form of engagement that is both authentically Muslim and fully Filipino.

His ongoing leadership at UP IIS ensures that future generations of students will inherit a balanced, historically informed, and ethically grounded perspective on Islam, the Bangsamoro, and Philippine society. In an era of quick soundbites and easy polarizations, Wadi's career is a quiet but powerful argument for depth, patience, and dialogue.

Challenges

Wadi's career has unfolded in a context that presents its own structural difficulties. The academic study of Islam and Muslim Filipino communities has long occupied a marginal position within Philippine higher education, underfunded and undervalued relative to its importance for national cohesion and peacebuilding. Advocating for the Bangsamoro cause within mainstream Philippine academia, navigating the sensitivities of Muslim–Christian relations, and sustaining rigorous scholarship on politically charged topics have all required not just intellectual skill but also personal resilience. His consistent re-appointment as dean across four terms suggests that he has managed these pressures with considerable grace, but the structural challenges facing UP IIS and Bangsamoro studies more broadly remain ongoing.

See Also

- University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies
- Bangsamoro
- Tausug people
- Mindanao peace process
- Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)
- Silsilah Dialogue Institute
- MindaNews
- Islamic Studies in the Philippines

References

- Wadi, Julkipli M. (1993). *Islamic Diplomacy and the OIC's Role in the Bangsamoro Question*. MA Thesis. University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies.
- Wadi, Julkipli M. (2005). "Braving Muslim–Christian Dialogue in the Philippines." Published essay on interfaith relations.
- "Crucible" column, MindaNews. Various dates. Authored by Julkipli M. Wadi.
- *Pangadjian* Journal of Islamic Studies. University of the Philippines Institute of Islamic Studies.
- Biographical profile document on Prof. Julkipli M. Wadi. Source document on file, BangsamoroPedia (wiki.maranaw.com).

External Links

- UP Institute of Islamic Studies, University of the Philippines Diliman (https://iis.upd.edu.ph)
- MindaNews — Source of the "Crucible" column (https://www.mindanews.com)
- BangsamoroPedia (https://wiki.maranaw.com)

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